Lesson 13: Sentence Essentials 1: Phrases, Sentence Parts and Simple Sentences

English Stage 2 (B2) · Unit 2: Sentences and Paragraph Types · American History

Adapted from Building Academic Writing Skills by Lin Cui, Harper College (CC BY-NC-SA 4.0): Unit 7 Sentence Essentials: I. Pretest; II. Differences Between a Phrase and a Sentence; III. Basic Sentence Parts and Sentence Patterns; IV. Sentence Structure #1: Simple Sentences.

In this lesson

This is the first of two lessons on Unit 7. You learn to tell a phrase from a sentence, to name the four basic parts of a sentence, to use the five basic sentence patterns, and to recognize simple sentences. Every correct sentence in academic writing is built on a "subject + verb" structure, so this is the base for the compound and complex sentences in Lesson 14.

Learning goals

After this lesson you should be able to:

- Tell a phrase from a sentence by looking for a "subject + verb" structure, not at the length.
- Identify the subject, verb, object and subject complement in a sentence.
- Write sentences in the five basic patterns and expand them with adjectives, adverbs and phrases.
- Recognize a simple sentence, including one with a compound subject or a compound verb.
- Divide run-together text into simple sentences with correct capital letters and periods.

Key language

Word or phrase	Meaning	Example
phrase	two or more words used together for part of an idea; no "subject + verb" structure	in the classroom
sentence	a "subject + verb" structure that expresses a complete idea	He woke up.
subject	who or what does the action, or what the sentence is about	The students work hard in this class.
verb	the action, or the word that explains the idea about the subject	The homework assignments seem interesting.
object	the receiver of the action; it comes after the verb	They have received good grades.
indirect object	the person who receives the direct object	The professor gives the students homework assignments.
linking verb	a verb that connects the subject with a word that describes it (be, seem, grow, turn)	The weather turns cold.

Word or phrase	Meaning	Example
subject complement	a noun or adjective after a linking verb that tells about the subject	This is a writing class.
simple sentence (independent clause)	a sentence with only one "subject + verb" group; it expresses a complete, independent idea	Learning is important.
compound subject	two or more subjects that share the same verb	Maria and Sung have three classes.
compound verb	two or more actions done by the same subject	They are taking classes and working part time.
energetic (adj)	active, full of energy	There are twenty young and energetic students.
premier (adj)	first in rank, leading	one of the nation's premier and largest community colleges

Rules and explanations

Phrase or sentence?

A **phrase** is two or more words used together for part of an idea, not a complete idea. There is no "subject + verb" structure in a phrase.

- Noun phrases: boys and girls, an excellent school, picture books
- Verb phrases: play together, read a story, learn shapes and colors
- Prepositional phrases (a preposition such as in, on or from + a noun): in the classroom, on the wall, from home to school

A **sentence** may contain different phrases. It:

- must have a "subject + verb" structure;
- always starts with a capital letter;
- must end with a period (.), a question mark (?) or an exclamation mark (!);
- must express a complete idea: "Are they learning shapes and colors in the classroom?"

Do not judge by length. Look for the "subject + verb" structure:

- Phrase: after a long nap on a beautiful mat in the corner of the nap room
- Sentence: He woke up.

Four basic parts of a sentence

Part	What it does	Example (the part in bold)
subject	shows who or what does the action, or what the sentence is about; usually comes first	**The writing class** is important.

Part	What it does	Example (the part in bold)
verb	usually comes after the subject; shows the action or explains the idea	The teacher **meets** the students in Room D-144 every week.
object	usually receives the action; comes after the verb	All the students have finished **homework** on time.
subject complement	usually follows a linking verb and shows what the subject is about; a noun or an adjective	This is **a writing class**. (noun) The students grow **confident** in writing. (adjective)

Five basic sentence patterns

Pattern	Examples
1. subject + verb	The semester has started. / Professors teach in colleges.
2. subject + linking verb + subject complement (noun or adjective)	This is a writing class. / The weather turns cold as the semester goes on.
3. subject + verb + direct object	We are taking a writing class. / I like my classmates.
4. subject + verb + indirect object + direct object	The professor gives the students homework assignments. / The students left the professor a note yesterday.
5. there + a form of "be"	There are twenty students in this class. / There was a quiz last week.

In pattern 4, the indirect object (the students) is the person who receives the direct object (homework assignments).

Expanding a sentence. Add adjectives, adverbs, phrases and clauses to make a basic sentence more interesting. The added parts are in bold:

- The students grow confident in writing. → The students **gradually** grow **more** confident in writing **as the semester goes on**.
- There are twenty students in this class. → There are twenty **young and energetic** students **from different countries** in this **writing** class.

Simple sentences

A simple sentence has only one "subject + verb" group, from the capital letter at the beginning to the end mark: "Students take classes." It is also called an **independent clause** (a clause is a group of words with a subject and a verb), because it explains a complete, independent idea. The book compares it to a single adult who lives an independent life.

A simple sentence can have more than one subject or verb, but they form only one group:

- Compound subject (two or more subjects share the same verb): "Are Maria, Sung, and Anna busy?"
- Compound verb (the same subject performs two or more actions): "They are taking classes and working part time."
- Both: "Maria and Sung study and work every day."

Note for Arabic speakers

- An Arabic sentence in the present can have no verb at all ("the class important"). An English sentence always needs a verb. Before an adjective or a noun that describes the subject, use a linking verb: "The writing class is important."
- Arabic writing often joins many clauses with "and" and commas. In English, end each complete sentence with a period and start the next one with a capital letter (Exercise 3).

Practice

1. Pretest, items 1-4. Is it a phrase or a sentence? (Items 5-10 are in Lesson 14.)

1. the Early Childhood Laboratory School
2. at Harper College
3. provide fun learning to children
4. The Early Childhood Laboratory School at Harper College provides fun learning to children.

2. Exercise 1. Write "phrase" or "sentence". The first one is an example.

1. a community college (example: phrase)
2. What a beautiful community college it is!
3. degrees and certificates
4. offer many programs
5. help students
6. The college offers many degrees and certificate programs to help students.
7. The students love the college for its excellent resources.
8. love the college
9. for its excellent resources
10. Are you enrolled in this college?
11. Where is it?
12. in a town called Palatine about thirty minutes of driving from downtown Chicago

3. Exercise 2. Here is more information about the Early Childhood Laboratory School (ECLS) at Harper College. (a) Arrange the words and phrases into sentences. Capitalize and punctuate where necessary. (b) Then expand sentences 2, 3 and 5 by adding adjectives, adverbs, phrases or clauses, and underline the added parts.

Example: provides / to many families / a childcare option / The Early Childhood Laboratory School

Sentence: The Early Childhood Laboratory School provides a childcare option to many families.

Expanded: The Early Childhood Laboratory School at Harper College provides an excellent child care option to many busy families in the community.

1. could be / for many students / taking care of their children / a challenge / and / Studying

2. for children / are / different activities / There
3. to this school / sends / Julio / three days a week / his daughter / My friend
4. goes to / He / in the morning / then / his own classes / drops her off / and
5. to check on Elma / often / He / goes to the ECLS
6. to see her play / stands / He / outside the playground / sometimes
7. observes / inside the school / Sometimes / and / her / goes / he
8. are / Julio / both happy / In the afternoon, / they / picks Elma up, / and

4. Exercise 3. Read the paragraph "Some Information about Harper College" in the lesson material. Separate each complete, simple sentence: put a period at the end and capitalize the first letter of the next sentence. (Commas have already been added.) Then write the subject and the verb of each sentence.

Example: in September 1967, Harper College formally opened in Palatine, Illinois

With corrections: In September 1967, Harper College formally opened in Palatine, Illinois. Subject: Harper College. Verb: opened.

Speak with your tutor

- "Give me ten groups of words about my university, some phrases and some sentences. I will say which is which and explain why."
- "Ask me six questions about my psychology course. I will answer in simple sentences. Tell me the subject, the verb and the pattern of each answer."
- "Give me five basic sentences. I will expand each one with adjectives, adverbs and phrases. Check that each is still a correct simple sentence."
- "Here is my paragraph: [paste]. Check that each sentence has a subject and a verb, and find any phrase that I wrote as a sentence."

Read aloud

Capitals show word stress. The mark | shows a short pause after a long subject; do not pause after a short one.

1. The Early Childhood Laboratory School at Harper College | provides fun learning to children.
2. The professor gives the students homework assignments.
3. The students gradually grow more confident in writing as the semester goes on.
4. There are twenty young and en·er·GET·ic students from different countries in this writing class.
5. Harper College is now one of the nation's pre·MIER and largest community colleges.

Writing task

Write a paragraph of 8 to 10 sentences about your university, college or psychology course, like "Some Information about Harper College" in Exercise 3.

- Use only simple sentences (one "subject + verb" group in each). You will revise this paragraph for sentence variety in Lesson 14, so keep it.
- Use each of the five basic patterns at least once, and write the pattern number (1-5) after each sentence.
- Include one compound subject and one compound verb.
- Expand at least three sentences with adjectives, adverbs or phrases.
- Underline the subject of each sentence and write the verb in bold.

Self-editing checklist:

- Every sentence has a subject and a verb.
- Every sentence starts with a capital letter and ends with a period, a question mark or an exclamation mark.
- No phrase stands alone as a sentence.
- A linking verb comes before each subject complement: "The library is quiet."
- Each sentence has only one "subject + verb" group.
- All five patterns are there.

Paste your draft into the chat and ask your tutor for feedback. Then rewrite it.

Answer key

1. Pretest (book): 1 phrase; 2 phrase; 3 phrase; 4 sentence.

2. Exercise 1 (book): 2 sentence; 3 phrase; 4 phrase; 5 phrase; 6 sentence; 7 sentence; 8 phrase; 9 phrase; 10 sentence; 11 sentence; 12 phrase.

3. Exercise 2. (a) (book)

1. Studying and taking care of their children could be a challenge for many students.
2. There are different activities for children.
3. My friend Julio sends his daughter to this school three days a week.
4. He drops her off in the morning and then goes to his own classes.
5. He often goes to the ECLS to check on Elma.
6. He sometimes stands outside the playground to see her play.
7. Sometimes he goes inside the school and observes her.
8. In the afternoon, Julio picks Elma up, and they are both happy.

A time phrase can also move to the front: "Three days a week, my friend Julio sends his daughter to this school."

(b) (example answer) 2. There are many different and creative activities for young children in each classroom. 3. My friend Julio happily sends his little daughter to this excellent school three days a week. 5. He often goes to the ECLS between his classes to check on Elma.

4. Exercise 3. The book gives no key. There are ten simple sentences (beginning ... end: subject / verb):

1. (example) In September 1967, ... Palatine, Illinois. (Harper College / opened)
2. It uses the name ... in the United States. (It / uses)
3. Dr. William Rainey Harper was ... the University of Chicago. (Dr. William Rainey Harper / was)
4. Harper College is now ... community colleges. (Harper College / is)
5. Every year, it serves ... Chicago's northwest suburbs. (it / serves)
6. Its academic programs ... and their careers. (Its academic programs / have been preparing)
7. Students can choose ... part time students. (Students / can choose)
8. Harper offers ... to help students financially. (Harper / offers)
9. Students should check ... for information. (Students / should check ... or call: a compound verb)
10. A registration specialist will provide step-by-step guidance. (A registration specialist / will provide)

"To honor", "to become" and "to help" are infinitives, not the main verbs. Note: "financial aid" has no plural, so "financial aids" is a mistake in the book's text.

My notes